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Kansas City, Missouri Councilman Troy Nash (left) greeted vice-president Al Gore last Saturday when he arrived in Kansas City at the Downtown Airport. SEE THE FULL STORY ON PAGE 3C.

Nash Presses Gore for More Money

During a recent trip to Kansas City, Vice President Al Gore, the Democratic nominee for President of the United States, visited two sites in Kansas City's Third Council District. But before the Vice President arrived at Montgall Park and Crispus Attucks School, about twenty-five dignitaries greeted him at the downtown airport. Among the dignitaries was 3rd District-at-Large City Councilman Troy Nash, who after an exchange of platitudes, pressed the Vice President for additional dollars for the 3rd District.

"I did not think I was being too direct with Vice President Gore, I just believe that I have to take advantage of any and all opportunities to lobby for dollars for the city. I subscribe to former Mayor Emanuel Cleaver's philosophy to economic development-come up with an idea that benefits the community and then go out and get the money," said Councilman Nash.

During the Cleaver administration, President Clinton and Vice President Gore were very helpful in providing federal dollars to major projects throughout the Kansas City area primarily through the Empowerment Zone and Enterprise Community (EZ/EC) Initiative.

The Empowerment Zone and Enterprise Community (EZ/EC) Initiative is a key element of President Clinton's and Vice President Gore's job creation strategy for America. Its purpose is to create jobs and business opportunities in the most economically distressed areas of inner cities and the rural heartland.

The EZ/EC effort provides tax incentives and performance grants and loans to create jobs and expand business opportunities. It also focuses on activities to support people looking for work: job training, childcare, and transportation.

On December 21, 1994, President Clinton and Vice president Gore designated 72 urban areas and 33 rural communities as Empowerment Zones or Enterprise Communities. They are receiving more than $1.5 billion in performance grants and more than $2.5 billion in tax incentives. Total public and private investment in the urban EZ/ECs already exceeds $4 billion.

As Supplemental Empowerment Zones, Los Angeles received a grant of $125 million and Cleveland, $90 million. Boston, Houston, Kansas City, KS/MO, and Oakland each received $25 million as Enhanced Enterprise Communities. The remaining 93 urban and rural areas received $3 million.

Employers in the urban and rural Empowerment Zones are eligible for wage tax credits, worth $3,000 for every employee hired who lives in the Empowerment Zone boundaries. EZ businesses also are eligible for increased tax expensing for equipment purchases. (EZ businesses may write off as an expense the cost of the depreciable, tangible personal property they purchase, up to $37,500 — $20,000 more than the normal $17,500 first-year write-off for business not in the EZ.)

"It's programs like these that help us leverage city, state, and private dollars that are vital to rebuilding our community. Besides it is important to remember that taking a chance is the price we pay for progression," said Councilman Nash.

Other dignitaries gathered at the airport included Bridgette Williams, President of the AFL-CIO State Senator Mary Bland, and State Representatives Melba Curls and Sharon Sanders-Brooks.